

The Tie Breaker

Australia's refusal to play a Davis Cup tie in Chennai due to security fears comes with the realisation that a precedent has been set and India needs to be an alert host

| By Sharda Ugra |

Did it start with the IPL moving to South Africa? Or with Lleyton Hewitt finding some form on clay? In any case, when Australia announced its decision to forfeit its Davis Cup tie in Chennai in early May due to security concerns around the elections, India's most predictable reaction was, "Not *you*. Not again."

That was only because India and Australia have most commonly (and not so long ago, grumpily) engaged with each other through cricket. In tennis, their ties have been far more cordial and in recent years, Australian tennis has sought to identify itself more and more with Asia. These days, the Australian Open is pitched as "The Grand Slam of Asia-Pacific" and now out gives wild cards to Asian champions. (Sania Mirza's breakout Australian Open appearance in 2005, for instance, came through a wild card from Melbourne). Asian officials work matches at the Aussie Open and promising Asian juniors have been flown over to be ball kids. Australian greats have been generous with their expertise at clinics in India and have worked often with Indian pros.

But in late March, after Tennis Australia "sought and received advice from a variety of sources", it asked for the Chennai tie to be moved and then refused to accept the verdict of the International Tennis Federation's (ITF) security experts. A perfectly friendly, non-antagonistic relationship then rapidly deteriorated into name-calling. Reasonable people lapsed into shrieking generalisations, there was a stampede of famous Aussie tennis names wanting to add to the tally of uninformed comment.

The All India Tennis Association (AITA) responded with a few robust, post-colonial blows of its own. The tie was forfeited, India gave itself a shot at the World Group and Australia, trying to scramble back to the elite themselves, were left kicking furniture.

Amongst the travelling Indians, there is disappointment—and a little bewilderment, "It is uncharacteristic of them," said Mahesh Bhupathi. "I'm surprised they didn't check out the situation with others," he added,

saying that no one from inside the Australia tennis community had so much as informally asked him about the situation on the ground. When asked whether better communication would not have helped on the part of the Indians themselves, AITA President Anil Khanna said that the tie had stayed with India precisely because the communication was good.

The Indians promised the Australians a ring of 200 policemen inside the 5,000-seat stadium and 100 additional security staff inside their hotel, a short five-minute drive from the Davis Cup venue. No arguments about the size and logistics of the IPL, the conduct of the Chennai Open in January and two ongoing international Futures events in Delhi during election season could change Australia's mind. Nor did the all-clear from the ITF's designated security team (and Australia is a member of the ITF's Davis Cup committee). By being willing to forfeit the tie and risk a one-year ban, Tennis Australia has convinced its own constituency that India was too dangerous for tennis.

Indians suspect it is something else: Australian No. 1 Lleyton Hewitt's reported reluctance to compete in Chennai's 40 degree heat and 100 per cent humidity. During the recent junior Fed Cup and Davis Cup events in Australia, more than one Aussie tennis insider mentioned to visitors that moves were on to get Hewitt to play the tie, but the chances looked bleak. Hewitt, 28, Australia's most successful Davis Cup singles player, has

just won his first ATP title in two years in Houston and is in the middle of his claycourt season, heading into the French Open next month. The Chennai tie was to be held on hard courts.

Sport is in the playing, not in the walking away and Australia has over-reacted badly and unreasonably. India's Davis Cup team has been given a push up the ladder and must not squander it.

As a sporting host, India itself must now be alert and responsive because a precedent has been set. When fear and suspicion hold the world by the throat, there is no reassurance to be found in an aggressive posture. ■

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